conduct themselves. People, as he put it, were of ‘diverse inclinations and diverse passions. They will perform either the whole or only a part of (their duty).’[34] His view was that being liberal was worthless without self-control, pure thoughts, gratitude, and solid devotion. It was a reiteration of what he had said in the same message earlier when distinguishing between a person fully established in dhamma from one merely charitable.[35] Religiosity was frequently expressed only through conscience-salving donations, and the emperor was making it known that he did not consider such giving sufficient.

His subjects would not have had a problem imbibing this part of his message. What is likely to have made them wary was the authoritarian tone with which he offered his opinion on how they ought and ought not to conduct their social rituals. An instance of this appears in the ninth edict, which expounds on the kinds of rites which Ashoka considered superficial and unsatisfactory: ‘auspicious ceremony on the occasion of illness, the wedding of a son, the wedding of a daughter, (and) the birth of children . . . on such occasions, the women folk (in particular) perform many and diverse (kinds of) ceremony which is trivial and meaningless.’[36] The people were warned that such acts lacked all efficacy whereas those associated with dhamma produced results. And dhamma, he repeated, comprised ‘proper courtesy to slaves and servants, reverence to elders, restraint in (one’s dealings with) living beings, (and) liberality to the Shramanas and Brahmanas.’[37]

The recurrence of dhamma and its vital relevance are obsessive. The core principles running through the edicts, of proper behaviour with parents, friends, and holy men, and giving up killing living beings (‘prananam’), are continuously elucidated, the eleventh edict offering a variation on the same theme. The results of acting in line with dhamma mean happiness in this world and endless merit in the next. The king’s